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21 April 2026

RE: HCB 2026-018

Dear Dr. Gienger:

I have reviews back from two reviewers and I have looked over your paper also. I am accepting your paper pending satisfactory revision. Both reviewers made numerous comments (mostly minor) but there are several significant comments that will require a bit of change to your manuscript. I need you to incorporate changes from the reviewers unless you disagree with a comment and can explain why the change shouldn't be made. The main concern is the need to do a better job describing your study design so that the reader is convinced that inferring habitat selection is appropriate. You found snakes with searches and not telemetry, but do not describe your search strategy in any detail. Please pay particular attention to this area of your paper. I have included comments from reviewers below and both reviewers made additional comments directly on the manuscript. I have made some format changes to the file by Reviewer 2.

Please send a clean revision back to me. It would be easiest for me if you would list changes requested by each reviewer (other than minor edits) and in a different font color explain how you dealt with the comment/requested change. I added in your Bios, which were not in the review copies. Please include author names, affiliations, and Acknowledgments in your revision, because these also were not given to the reviewers. Once I am satisfied with your revision based on scientific concerns, I will make a thorough copy edit of your paper and request separate high-resolution photos and graphs. If you choose to submit your revision, I will need it no later than 21 August 2026. Otherwise, any resubmission will be considered a new submission and the review process will begin anew.

David J. Germano, Ph.D., Section Editor
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Reviewer 1

Please see the attached word document for my edits/comments.

Reviewer 2

The authors present a most informative, thorough, and well organized report of habitat selection and use by cottonmouths in wetland habitat within Cheatham County, Tennessee. The introduction is well structured and places the investigation in an interesting theoretical context of niche space. Well done.

Please see my comment within the introduction regarding the considerations for determining if a species is a habitat generalist or specialist. This section just needs clarity as my question will most likely be shared by other readers. Please explain with relation to the (Devictor et al. 2008; Poff and Zimmerman 2010) citations used. I acknowledge (in my second comment) that generalists and specialists are correctly identified followed by the citations (Macarthur and Wilson 1967; Adler and Wilson 1987; Fournier et al. 2015; Büchi and Vuilleumier 2016). Ultimately, are these ideas in contradictions?

The detailed analyses in this paper are to be commended. Both thorough and accurate.

I have suggested a couple of citations (Reinert 1984 and Lutterschmidt et al. 2022) within the manuscript and where in the manuscript these citations should be considered. Each of these should receive some summary of their methods and findings.

Please see the manuscript for minor suggestion to improve readability in certain sections. Overall these are very minor changes in sentence structure.